Sharing and delegating calendars

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Summary

This article explains how users can gain access to a shared mailbox calendar and how to delegate editor permissions on a team calendar. It provides self-help steps for end-users to request access or manually add the shared calendar, and a detailed procedure for the Messaging & Collaboration service-desk team to grant the required Full Access, Send As, and delegate permissions, followed by verification steps.

Symptoms

- Shared mailbox does not appear in the Outlook folder pane
- Calendar under the shared mailbox is missing or greyed out
- Error message: "You do not have permission to open this folder. Contact the folder owner or an administrator."
- Unable to create or edit meetings in the shared calendar - receives "You don't have sufficient permission" prompt
- Shared mailbox appears but calendar items show as free/busy only

Common causes

- Full Access or Send As permissions not granted on the shared mailbox
- Delegate editor (or reviewer) permission missing on the calendar folder
- Automapping disabled or Outlook cached mode not updated
- Permissions replicated but Outlook client needs a restart or offline address book sync
- User is looking at a secondary mailbox profile without the shared mailbox added

Overview

Sharing a calendar in Outlook lets team members view and edit each other's schedules. For a shared mailbox, the mailbox itself must first be granted Full Access (and optionally Send As) so that Outlook can auto-map it to the user's profile. After the mailbox is visible, calendar delegation is set separately: the mailbox owner (or a delegated editor) grants specific permission levels (Reviewer, Author, Editor) on the calendar folder. This article covers both the mailbox-level access and the calendar-delegation steps.

Self-Help Procedure: Request or Add a Shared Calendar

Follow these steps if you need access to a shared mailbox calendar or want to add a shared calendar that you already have permissions for. The procedure works in Outlook for Windows, Outlook for Mac, and Outlook on the web.

1. Open Outlook and navigate to the Calendar view.
2. In the left-hand pane, right-click "My Calendars" (or "Calendars" in OWA) and select "Add Calendar" -> "From Address Book".
3. Type the name or email address of the shared mailbox (e.g., team-projects@acme.example) and click "Go".
4. Select the mailbox from the results and click "OK". Outlook will attempt to auto-map the mailbox if you have Full Access permission.
5. If the mailbox appears but its calendar is empty or shows only free/busy, right-click the shared mailbox's calendar, choose "Properties" -> "Permissions", and verify that you have at least "Reviewer" (to see details) or "Author/Editor" (to create/edit items). If the permission level is insufficient, contact the mailbox owner or the service desk to request delegate editor rights.
6. Restart Outlook (or close and reopen the app) to ensure any permission changes are reflected.

Service Desk Procedure: Grant Permissions and Verify

Use this procedure when a ticket indicates missing access to a shared mailbox calendar or inability to edit a team calendar. It outlines the exact PowerShell/Exchange admin actions required and the verification steps to confirm successful propagation.

1. Confirm the request: note the shared mailbox SMTP address (e.g., team-projects@acme.example) and the

requesting user's UPN (e.g., jane.doe@acme.example).
2. Open Exchange Online PowerShell (Connect-ExchangeOnline -UserPrincipalName <admin>).
3. Grant Full Access and Send As permissions on the mailbox:
Add-MailboxPermission -Identity "team-projects@acme.example" -User "jane.doe@acme.example" -AccessRights FullAccess -AutoMap $true
Add-RecipientPermission -Identity "team-projects@acme.example" -Trustee "jane.doe@acme.example" -AccessRights SendAs
4. If the request is for calendar delegation only (no mailbox access needed), set the calendar folder permission:
Set-MailboxFolderPermission -Identity "team-projects@acme.example:\Calendar" -User "jane.doe@acme.example" -AccessRights Editor
5. Notify the user to restart Outlook (or wait up to 30 minutes for automap to take effect).
6. Verify propagation:
Get-MailboxPermission -Identity "team-projects@acme.example" -User "jane.doe@acme.example" | Format-List User,AccessRights,IsInherited
Get-MailboxFolderPermission -Identity "team-projects@acme.example:\Calendar" -User "jane.doe@acme.example" | Format-List User,AccessRights

Verification and Troubleshooting

After permissions are granted, ask the user to perform the following checks. If the issue persists, collect the listed information before escalating.

1. In Outlook, verify that the shared mailbox appears under the folder pane. If not, run "File -> Account Settings -> Account Settings -> Change -> More Settings -> Advanced -> Add" and manually add the mailbox by its email address.
2. Check the calendar permissions again via right-click -> Properties -> Permissions to ensure the expected level (Editor) is present.
3. Send a test meeting invitation from the shared calendar and confirm that the invitation is sent with the shared mailbox as the organizer (Sent Items should show the shared mailbox).
4. If the mailbox appears but calendar items show as free/busy only, confirm that the user has at least "Reviewer" permission; upgrade to "Author" or "Editor" as needed.
5. Collect: screenshot of the folder pane, the exact error message, output of Get-MailboxPermission and Get-MailboxFolderPermission for the affected user, and the user's Outlook version (File -> Office Account -> About Outlook).

Additional Tips and Best Practices

Encourage teams to use a dedicated shared mailbox for project calendars rather than personal mailboxes, as this simplifies permission management. Regularly review calendar delegation rights quarterly to remove stale users. Educate users to use the Outlook "Open Shared Calendar" feature instead of dragging mailboxes between profiles, which reduces sync issues. Remember that Full Access with AutoMap $true will only automap in Outlook clients that are online and using cached mode; users on Outlook on the web will always see the mailbox once permissions are granted.

When to escalate

If after verifying permissions the user still cannot see or edit the calendar, escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration L2 team. Include the shared mailbox SMTP address, the user's UPN, screenshots of the folder pane and any error messages, the output of Get-MailboxPermission and Get-MailboxFolderPermission for the user, and the Outlook client version and mode (cached/online).

Keywords: shared mailbox, calendar sharing, delegate calendar, Full Access, Send As, Outlook calendar permissions, automap, Set-MailboxFolderPermission, Add-MailboxPermission